PROLOGUE

RAJIV GANDHI, A FORMER PRIME MINISTER OF INDIA, WAS assassinated on 21 May 1991 at a place called Sriperumbudur in Tamil Nadu. The assassin was an adolescent girl named Dhanu who was made into a human bomb. She got herself exploded at 10.19 p.m. at close proximity with the visiting former Prime Minister. In a trice the life of Rajiv Gandhi was snuffed out and his body smashed into smithereens. As for the assassin, nothing except a few pieces of charred limbs and her sundered head were found. In the explosion, the lives of eighteen others were also extinguished. Investigation pointed to a minutely orchestrated cabal, masterminded by conspirators to extirpate the former Prime Minister from this terrestrial terrain. In the final charge sheet made by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), all the twenty-six appellants now before us were arraigned as members of the conspiracy, which targeted, inter alia, Rajiv Gandhi. The Special Judge who tried the case found all the twenty-six appellants guilty of various offences charged, the gravamen of them being Section 302 read with Section 120-B of the IPC. All of them were hence convicted of those offences and sentenced to death.[1]

Justice K.T. Thomas J.
Supreme Court of India